
UX EVALUATION · HEURISTICS & UX LAWS

PhonePe — Send Money Flow

A Product Manager's usability evaluation of the UPI money-transfer journey, mapped to Nielsen's heuristics and core UX laws — with redesign recommendations.

Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

Hick's · Fitts's · Jakob's

Figma Redesigns

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What we evaluated, and why this flow

Product

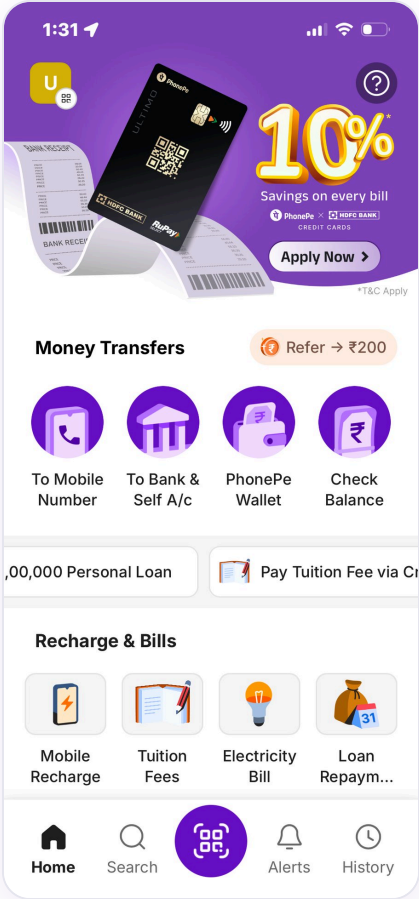
PhonePe — India's market-leading UPI app (~46–48% of UPI transaction volume), with deep penetration across Tier-2/3 and rural India.

Selected flow: Send Money (UPI transfer)

The core peer-to-peer payment journey — the most-used action in the app, and where friction has the highest user impact.

Reference point

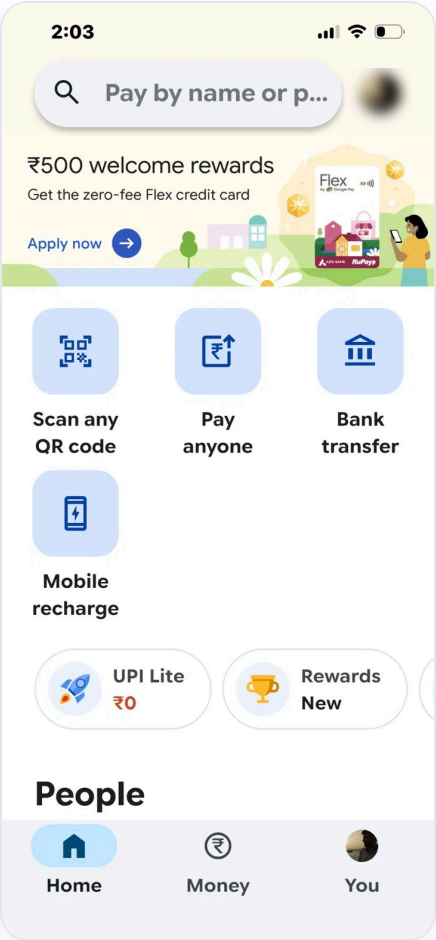
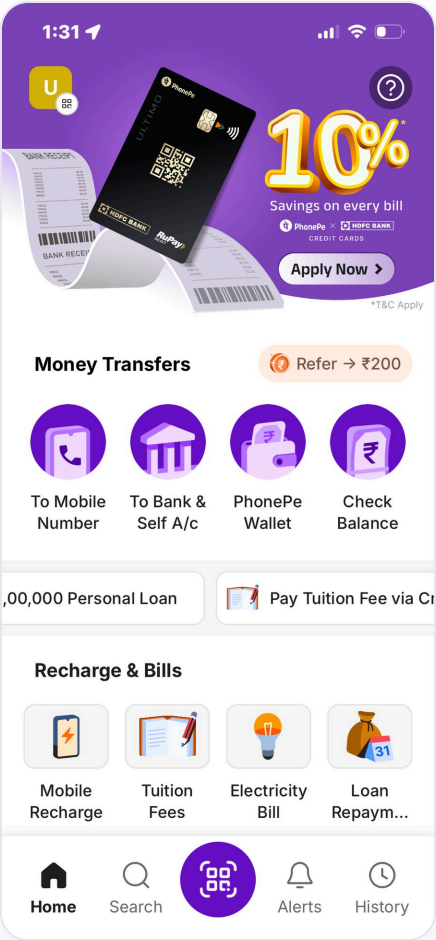
Google Pay is used selectively throughout as a contrast to sharpen each finding — not as a full competitor audit.



THE USER JOURNEY EVALUATED



Dense by design, not by accident



Tradeoff · Aesthetic & Minimalist Design

PhonePe's home screen carries ads, financial-product promos and dense icon grids. As a **standalone, pre-IPO company**, it must monetise the interface directly. Google Pay — subsidised by Alphabet's ad business — can afford a minimal screen. **The density is a business-model consequence, not a careless design.**

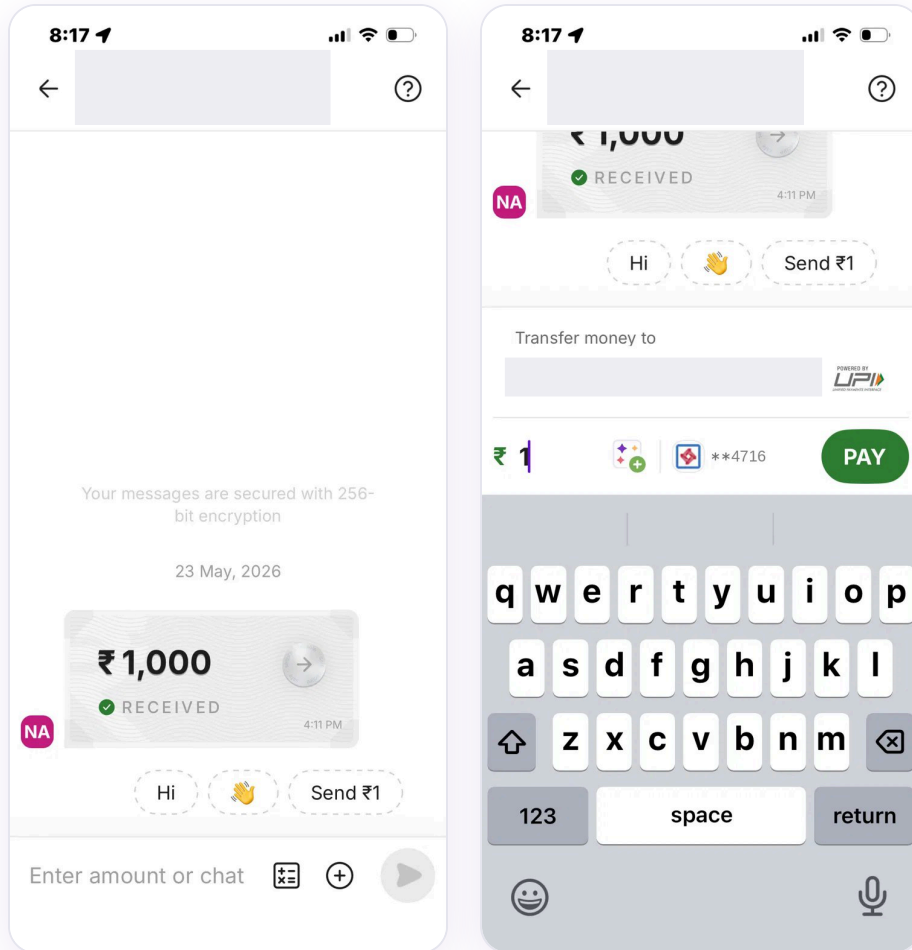
Positive · Fitts's Law

Primary actions sit where the thumb naturally rests — QR scan centre-bottom (largest target), Money Transfers in the mid-zone. Ads sit up top, seen but not blocking reach.

Positive · Help & Documentation

A help "?" icon is consistently available top-right on every screen of the flow.

Is this a payment, or a chat?



Issue · Consistency & Standards + Match with Real World

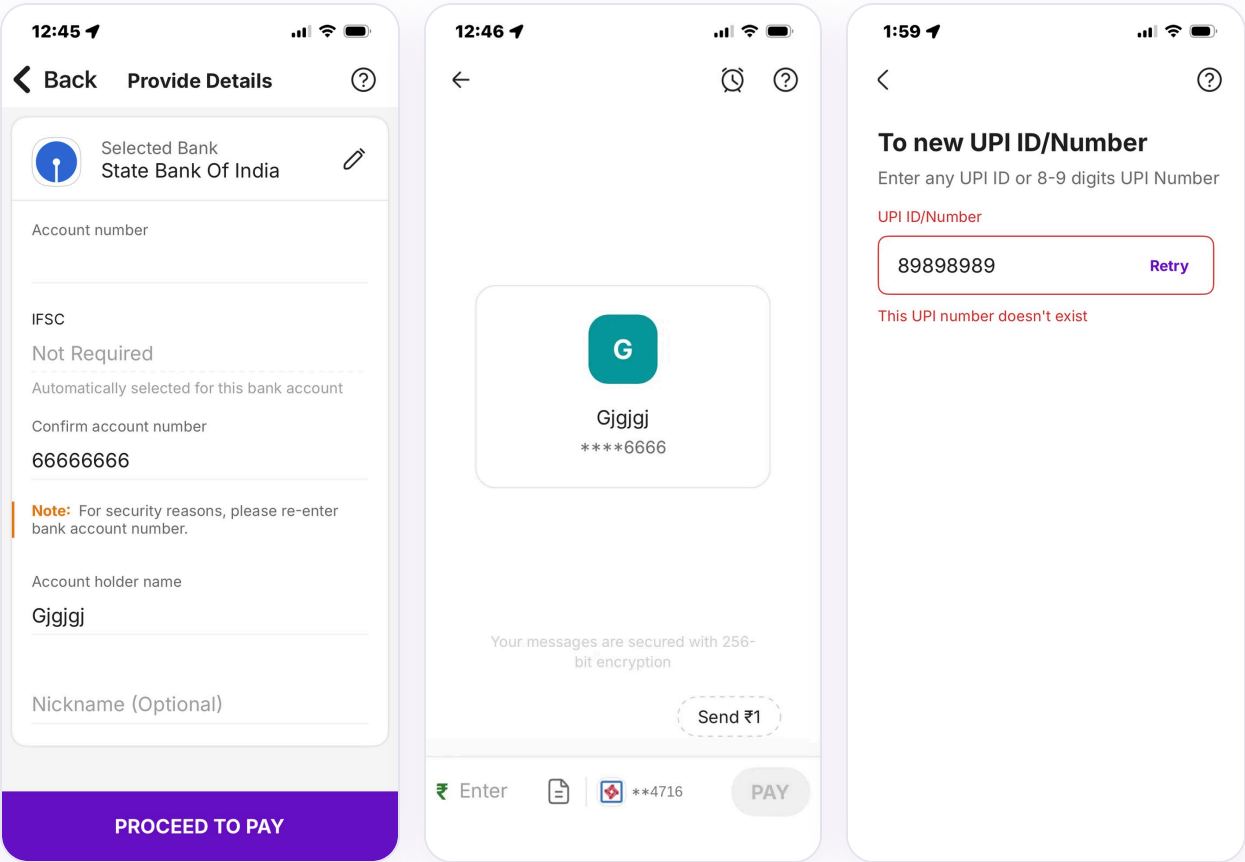
When paying a saved contact, the screen becomes a **chat thread** — the field reads "Enter amount or chat", reply bubbles appear, and a messaging-style send arrow sits where a Pay button should be. The primary task (sending money) shares one input with a secondary one (chatting).

Google Pay keeps **Pay, Request and Message** as **separate, labelled actions**. PhonePe even proves it knows better — its bank-transfer path uses a clean amount-only input.

Positive on the same flow

Once an amount is entered, a **verified banking name with a green shield** appears before payment — a strong trust signal (Visibility of System Status).

A fake account, saved without a single check



Issue · Error Prevention + Visibility of System Status

A random account number and a gibberish name were entered. PhonePe skipped IFSC ("Not required"), **saved it as a real beneficiary**, and let the flow reach the payment screen — with **no confirmation of who is being paid**.

The tell (far right): the very same app validates a UPI ID instantly — "This UPI number doesn't exist." PhonePe knows how to validate; it just doesn't on the bank-account path. Users trust a check that isn't happening.

The tradeoff: skipping IFSC follows **Recognition over Recall** — but trades away **Error Prevention**. GPay resolves the same tension with a searchable IFSC dropdown + upfront validation.

Usability issues & heuristic mapping

Issue	Heuristic Violated	How to Improve
Bank-transfer flow saves unverified / fake accounts with no recipient confirmation before the UPI PIN screen	Error Prevention; Visibility of System Status	Add a searchable IFSC dropdown for users who want it; show the verified recipient name with a green tick before proceeding
Send-money screen merges payment and chat in one field, forcing a QWERTY keyboard with small number keys	Consistency & Standards; Match between System and Real World	Separate amount entry from chat; add a distinct "Message" button beside the suggestion chips; trigger a numeric keypad for amount
Home-screen visual density — ads and promos compete with the primary payment actions for attention	Aesthetic & Minimalist Design	Increase visual contrast on the Money Transfers block; personalise section ordering by the user's most frequent action

Mapping to UX Laws

Hick's Law

The dense home screen — ads, transfers, recharges, bills — increases the time to decide on the payment action.

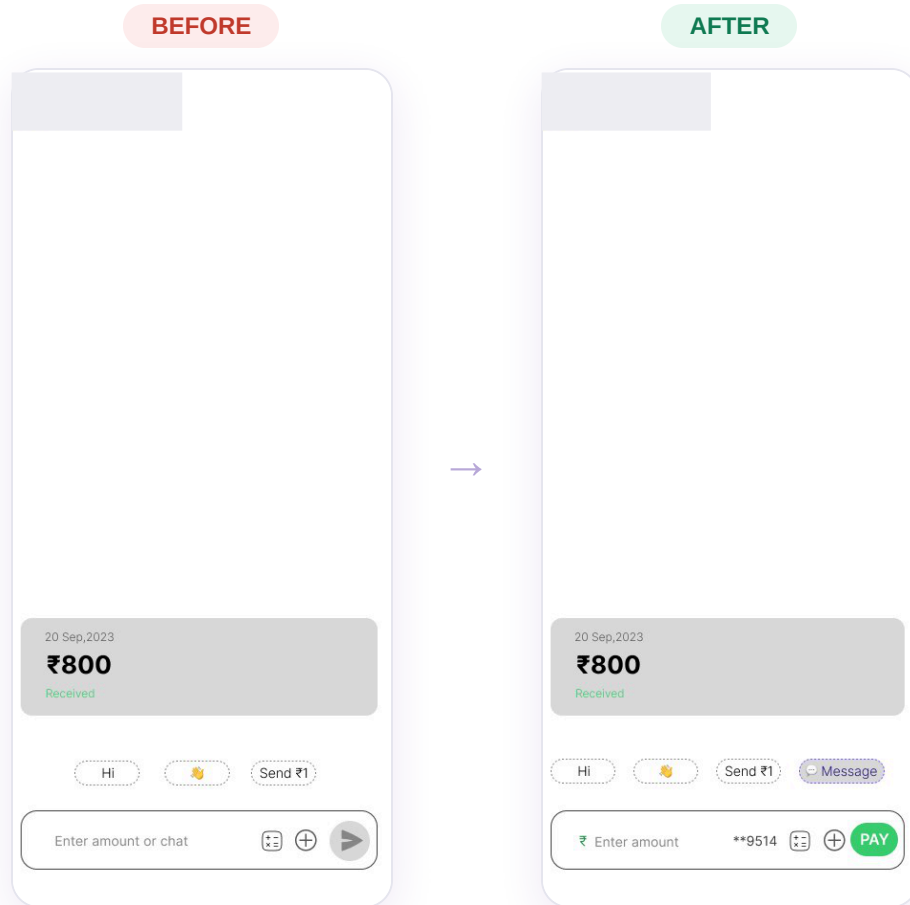
Fitts's Law

QR & primary buttons sit in the thumb zone (positive). Larger numeric keys would also reduce wrong-amount errors.

Jakob's Law

The chat metaphor borrows a familiar pattern; labels suit PhonePe's mass-market base vs GPay's fluent users — same law, different segments.

Untangling payment from chat



What changed

- The input field now reads **"Enter amount"** only, with a ₹ symbol — signalling a money-only field.
- A separate **"Message"** chip joins the existing quick-replies, giving chat its own clearly-labelled home.
- A green **PAY** button appears inline with the linked account — no ambiguity about the action.
- An amount-only field naturally triggers a **numeric keypad** with larger keys (Fitts's Law) — fewer wrong amounts.

Designed for PhonePe, not copied from GPay: chat is retained (PhonePe's users may rely on it) — it's simply separated from the payment action, not removed.

What this evaluation really showed



Distinguish flaws from tradeoffs

Several "issues" were dropped after testing — they were deliberate tradeoffs, not failures. The skill isn't listing problems; it's telling genuine friction apart from intentional design decisions.



Design traces back to strategy

PhonePe's density, wording and icons all follow from its business model and mass-market segment. Reading an interface backward to its strategy is a core PM skill.



Solve within constraints

The strongest redesign doesn't copy the competitor — it fixes the problem while respecting PhonePe's users, revenue model and reality.

Bottom line: Good UX evaluation isn't about finding the most problems — it's about finding the *real* ones, understanding *why* the design is the way it is, and recommending fixes that work for *this* product's users and business.